

Theme - Workbook 2

Choose the strongest theme and the evidence that best develops it.

How to use this workbook

This workbook emphasizes evidence for theme and plausible competing interpretations. More than one theme may sound reasonable, but choose the one most strongly supported by the passage as written.

Before you start

- Compare themes by evidence. Count the important moments each interpretation explains.
- Prefer the theme that fits the ending and the turning point. It should also make sense of earlier
- details.
- Reject extremes. A strong literary theme rarely needs always, never, everyone, or no one.

Text 1 - The Returned Book

Jon found a library book under a bench after the building had closed. He considered leaving it by the door, but rain had started, so he carried it home. The next morning he returned the book at opening time. The librarian thanked him and explained that another student had been searching for it because her notes were tucked inside. That afternoon, Jon noticed a wallet on a cafeteria chair. This time he picked it up without hesitating and walked straight to the office.

1. Which theme is most strongly developed?

- A. One responsible choice can make later responsible choices feel more natural. B. Libraries should stay open later during rainy weather. C. People lose important belongings too often. D. Returning lost items always leads to a reward.

2. Which detail provides the strongest evidence for that theme?

- A. Rain begins after the library closes. B. The book contains another student's notes. C. Jon picks up the wallet without hesitating and takes it to the office. D. The librarian thanks Jon.

Text 2 - The Empty Frame

After moving into a new apartment, Priya placed photographs on every shelf except one. She had planned to put a picture from her old neighborhood there, but each time she chose one, it made the room feel temporary. Months later, a neighbor invited her to a street festival. Priya took a photograph of several people from the building laughing beneath paper lanterns. She printed it the next day and placed it in the empty frame beside the older photographs.

3. Which theme is most strongly developed?

- A. A sense of belonging can grow through new shared experiences without erasing earlier connections. B. People should replace old photographs after they move. C. Street festivals are the best way to meet neighbors. D. Priya cannot decide which old photograph to display.

4. Which detail most strongly develops the theme?

- A. Priya has photographs on several shelves. B. She places the new festival photograph beside the older photographs. C. The festival has paper lanterns. D. She moved months earlier.

Text 3 - The Recipe Card

Marco insisted on following his grandfather's soup recipe exactly, even though the card listed a vegetable that was no longer available locally. His mother suggested a substitute, but Marco refused because he wanted the soup to taste "the right way." When he finally called his grandfather, he learned that the original recipe had changed many times depending on what the family could find. Marco used the substitute. At dinner, his grandfather tasted the soup and asked Marco what he might try next time.

5. Which theme is best supported?

- A. Traditions can remain meaningful even when people adapt how they practice them.
- B. Old recipes are always better than new recipes.
- C. Families should grow every ingredient they need.
- D. Marco is unable to find one vegetable for a soup recipe.

6. Which detail best supports the theme?

- A. Marco wants the soup to taste right.
- B. His mother suggests a substitute.
- C. His grandfather explains that the recipe changed many times depending on available ingredients.
- D. The family eats dinner together.

Text 4 - The Bench by the Court

After missing two free throws at the end of a close game, Dani stayed on the bench long after the gym emptied. She replayed the shots in her head and told herself she had ruined the game. The next day, her teammate Sienna arrived early and asked Dani to practice free throws with her. Sienna missed the first three. Dani laughed in surprise, then began passing the ball back after each attempt. They kept practicing until the custodian turned off half the lights.

7. Which theme is most strongly developed?

- A. Sharing setbacks with others can make failure feel less isolating and easier to work through. B. Athletes should practice until a gym closes. C. Free throws decide every basketball game. D. Dani misses two shots at the end of a game.

8. Which detail most strongly supports that theme?

- A. The game is close. B. Dani stays on the bench after the gym empties. C. Sienna misses her first three attempts and continues practicing with Dani. D. The custodian turns off some lights.

Answer key and reasoning

1. A. A is supported by Jon's first deliberate decision and his faster response the second time. The story does not mention a reward.
2. C. C directly shows that the earlier experience has influenced Jon's later behavior.
3. A. A fits the old photos, the empty frame, and the new festival photo. D describes the problem but not the larger idea.
4. B. Placing old and new memories together shows that new belonging does not require rejecting the past.
5. A. A fits the history of the recipe, Marco's change, and the grandfather's openness to future variation.
6. C. C directly reveals that adaptation has always been part of the tradition.
7. A. A is supported by Dani's self-blame, Sienna's imperfect practice, and the pair continuing together.
8. C. C directly demonstrates shared imperfection and collaborative persistence.

Mistake check

- Two themes seem possible? Choose the one that explains the largest number of important choices and
- changes.
- Theme sounds like advice? Rewrite it as an idea the story develops rather than a command to the
- reader.

- Theme is too broad? Remove absolute words and reconnect the idea to the character's actual experience.